

Story One

Life Force

Spotlight: Gracie · Herb: Chamomile

Why does a cut heal?

Gracie's finger was bleeding and she was not going to cry about it.

She pulled her hand back from the rosebush and looked at it the way she looked at most things that surprised her — with suspicion. A thin line of red was crossing her index finger. It was a very small cut. But it stung, and the fact that it stung when she hadn't done anything wrong did not seem fair.

"It bit me," she announced.

Nobody was in the garden to hear her. Bear was there, but he was busy with something under the basil, and Bear did not count.

She said it anyway. Some things you say out loud even when nobody is listening, and Gracie said most of them.

She pressed her lips together and stared the rosebush down. It did not look sorry. It just kept blooming its small pink flowers — the ones Vovó cut and dried and turned into things that smelled nice — as if it had not just bitten the hand of somebody important. "You're not my friend anymore," Gracie informed it. She was six, and she could hold a grudge against a rosebush, a brother, or a Tuesday, and she would hold this one exactly as long as she pleased.

But she did not cry. Crying was for the sad parts in books — the kind that made Evie cry, though Evie also cried at the

"Your shorts," Vovó said.

happy parts, and most of the parts in between. Gracie loved her sister with her whole fierce heart and did not understand her one bit. She blinked hard, twice, and decided the stinging could be finished now whether it agreed or not.

The blood was small but stubborn, and Gracie respected stubborn. She wiped her finger on her shorts — already the color of everything she did outside — and went to find Vovó.

The kitchen smelled like something green and warm. Vovó was at the counter with her mortar and pestle, grinding something that looked like dried flowers. She didn't look up when Gracie came in.

Vovó almost never looked up when somebody came in. Looking up was for emergencies. Vovó's particular gift was knowing whether something was an emergency without lifting her head — by the sound of the footsteps, by the rhythm of the breathing, by the way the screen door had closed. She had been doing it Gracie's whole life.

"The rosebush bit me."

Vovó set down the pestle. She looked at Gracie's finger, then at Gracie's face, then back at the finger. She took Gracie's hand and held it under the light the way she held everything

she was examining — without urgency, without alarm, just looking.

"Sit," she said.

Gracie sat on the stool. Vovó ran the finger under cool water at the sink, gentle and quick, and pressed a clean cloth against it. Then she just held it there, which was the part Gracie found most confusing. She wasn't doing anything complicated. She wasn't putting anything on it. She was just holding a cloth against a finger and waiting.

Gracie had expected something more. Some ointment. A bandage. A small ceremony, maybe, in which the cut was officially recognized. Instead Vovó just held a cloth against her finger and watched a clock on the wall that Gracie could not see from her stool. The clock ticked. The kettle made its quiet not-yet-boiling sound.

"Is it bad?" Gracie asked.

"No."

"Then why aren't you doing something?"

Vovó looked at her. Something moved through her eyes — not quite a laugh, not quite a smile. Something in between. "Something is already being done," she said. "I am just staying out of the way."

Gracie looked at the cloth. She wanted to check underneath it but Vovó was still holding it, so she couldn't. "How do you know it'll stop?"

"Because your body started before I did." Vovó lifted the cloth just enough to look, then pressed it back. "Right now — without you telling it to, without you thinking about it — your body is building a wall."

Gracie frowned. "A wall."

"Little pieces in your blood. Tiny ones. They are rushing to the cut right now. Stacking themselves up. Making a plug." She said it plainly, the way she said everything, like it was obvious once you knew it. "Your body has been doing this your whole life. Every scratch. Every scrape. You never had to learn it. You never had to ask."

Gracie looked at her finger — or at the cloth covering it — and tried to imagine tiny pieces rushing toward a cut she couldn't see, stacking themselves up on her behalf without any instructions from her. Something happening inside her that she had never known about, that had been happening her whole life.

"Why?" she said.

"Why what?"

"Why does it know how to do that?"

Vovó was quiet for a moment. Not the quiet of someone who didn't know. The quiet of someone letting a question land where it was supposed to land.

In the yard, Bear had abandoned the basil and was making his way toward the open kitchen door with the focused expression of a dog who has decided something is about to happen.

"That," Vovó said, "is the right question."

She made chamomile tea.

Gracie sat at the table with a small bandage on her finger — the cut had already slowed, exactly like Vovó said it would — and watched Vovó move around the kitchen, barefoot on the tile, knowing where everything was without looking. Her hand went to where the chamomile jar was, and the chamomile jar was there. Her hand went to the kettle, and the kettle was there. It was as if the kitchen had agreed with Vovó, a long time ago, to keep its things where her hand expected them.

"Is chamomile for cuts?" Gracie asked.

"No. Chamomile is for the nervous system." Vovó set a mug in front of her. The tea was pale yellow, almost gold. "You are wound up like a spring right now. I can see it in your shoulders."

"Smell it first," Vovó said.

Gracie didn't know she was wound up. She looked at her shoulders. They did seem a little high. She tried to put them down and found that it took actual effort.

Gracie lowered her face toward the mug. Steam rose against her cheeks. The smell was soft and warm and a little bit like hay, but nicer than hay — like the hay had been left in a sunny field and something calm had been added to it.

Her shoulders came down. She hadn't told them to.

"What does it smell like to you?" Vovó asked.

Gracie thought about it seriously. She was not someone who answered questions carelessly. "Like outside. But the good kind of outside."

Vovó made a small sound that was not quite a laugh. "That is a very good answer."

That was when Bear made his move.

He had been standing in the doorway for about forty-five seconds, pretending he was not interested in the mug on the table. He was a terrible pretender. He approached with great dignity, put his chin on the edge of the table, raised his nose over the lip of the mug, and took one long, serious, professional sniff.

Then he sneezed. Not a small sneeze. A sneeze that started somewhere behind his eyes and traveled all the way to his back legs, lifting them slightly off the floor. He looked profoundly surprised. He stared at the mug. He sneezed again. He backed up two steps, reconsidered the mug from a safer distance, and sneezed a third time for good measure.

Gracie laughed. She hadn't meant to — it came out before she could stop it, which was the best kind of laugh.

Vovó did not laugh, but the corners of her eyes did something. "Even Bear's body knows," she said, picking up her own mug, "what it likes and what it doesn't. He did not decide that. His nose told him before his brain could."

Gracie picked up the mug and drank. It tasted like it smelled — warm and gentle and a little like the good kind of outside. Something in her chest, which she hadn't noticed was tight, loosened very slightly.

Later, when the tea was gone and the bandage on her finger had stopped being interesting, Gracie went back to the garden.

The rosebush was still there, completely unbothered, still blooming its small pink flowers. Bear had found his patch of late afternoon sun and was asleep in it, his paws twitching over some dream she would never know about. The chamomile was growing in the corner bed — she could see

the white flowers from where she stood, small and cheerful, shaped like tiny suns.

It was strange, she thought, that the chamomile had been there the whole time. Right there in the corner bed. While she had been bleeding and walking to the kitchen and sitting on the stool, the chamomile had been here, growing, standing patient in the late afternoon sun. It had not known her name. It had not needed to. It had been ready for her for as long as it had been here, which was probably a long time.

She sat on the low stone wall and held out her finger and looked at it. There was a thin pink line where the cut had been. It was not bleeding. It had sealed itself while she was drinking tea and laughing at a dog, and she had not noticed when it happened.

Vovó came and sat beside her. She was carrying a small bunch of chamomile flowers she'd cut from the corner bed — the white ones with yellow centers, each one shaped like it had decided to be a sun and meant it. She put one in Gracie's hand without explaining why.

Gracie held it carefully. The petals were softer than she expected. The flower was very small — smaller than her thumbprint. It did not look like the kind of flower that could do anything important. And yet it had been waiting for her, and for the children before her, and the children before those.

"It's still going," she said. She meant her finger. The quiet aliveness under the skin.

"It will be for a while," Vovó said. "Healing is not one moment. It is many small moments, one after another, most of them invisible. The body does not rush. It does what is needed, in the order it is needed, and it does not stop until it is done."

Gracie turned the chamomile over. She wondered if the plant knew what it could do, or if it just did it the way her body just did it — without being asked, without being told, without needing to understand the reason.

"Vovó," she said.

"Mm."

"Why did God put healing inside people? Why didn't He just make it so we don't get hurt?"

Vovó was quiet. A real quiet, the kind she let go on until it had finished being quiet on its own. "I have thought about that," she said finally. "For many years." She looked at the garden. "I think He put healing inside us for the same reason He put chamomile in the ground. So that when we are hurt, we remember that He thought of this already. Before we were born. Before the rosebush. Before everything."

She put her hand over Gracie's — both of them holding the flower now — and said quietly what she always said when something mattered. "God breathed life into you, minha filha." Her thumb moved once across the back of Gracie's hand. "Your body knows things you never told it."

Gracie didn't say anything. She was looking at the chamomile, thinking about tiny walls and invisible healings, and the fact that something in her had been working on her behalf all afternoon — without being asked, without knowing her name, without stopping.

She had questions now.

The good kind.